

Chapter XVI

Further Adventures of Tommy



FROM a darkness punctuated with throbbing stabs of fire, Tommy dragged his senses slowly back to life. When he at last opened his eyes, he was conscious of nothing but an excruciating pain through his temples. He was vaguely aware of unfamiliar surroundings. Where was he? What had happened? He blinked feebly. This was not his bedroom at the 'Ritz'. And what the devil was the matter with his head?

'Damn!' said Tommy, and tried to sit up. He had remembered. He was in that sinister house in Soho. He uttered a groan and fell back. Through his almost-closed lids he reconnoitred carefully.

'He is coming to,' remarked a voice very near Tommy's ear. He recognized it at once for that of the bearded and efficient German, and lay artistically inert. He felt that it would be a pity to come round too soon; and until the pain in his head became a little less acute, he felt quite incapable of collecting his wits. Painfully he tried to puzzle out what had happened. Obviously somebody must have crept up behind him as he listened and struck him down with a blow on the head. They knew him now for a spy, and would in all probability give him short shrift. Undoubtedly he was in a tight place. Nobody knew where he was, therefore he need expect no outside assistance, and must depend solely on his own wits.

'Well, here goes,' murmured Tommy to himself, and repeated his former remark.

'Damn!' he observed, and this time succeeded in sitting up.

In a minute the German stepped forward and placed a glass to his lips, with the brief command 'Drink.' Tommy obeyed. The potency of the draught made him choke, but it cleared his brain in a marvellous manner.

He was lying on a couch in the room in which the meeting had been held. On one side of him was the German, on the other the villainous-faced door-keeper who had let him in. The others were grouped together at a little distance away. But Tommy missed one face. The man known as Number One was no longer of the company.

'Feel better?' asked the German, as he removed the empty glass.

'Yes, thanks,' returned Tommy cheerfully.

'Ah, my young friend, it is lucky for you your skull is so thick. The good Conrad struck hard.' He indicated the evil-faced doorkeeper by a nod. The man grinned.

Tommy twisted his head round with an effort.

'Oh,' he said, 'so you're Conrad, are you? It strikes me the thickness of my skull was lucky for you too. When I look at you I feel it's almost a pity I've enabled you to cheat the hangman.'

The man snarled, and the bearded man said quietly:

'He would have run no risk of that.'

'Just as you like,' replied Tommy. 'I know it's the fashion to run down the police. I rather believe in them myself.'

His manner was nonchalant to the last degree. Tommy Beresford was one of those young Englishmen not distinguished by any special intellectual ability, but who are emphatically at their best in what is known as a 'tight place.' Their natural diffidence and caution fall from them like a glove. Tommy realized perfectly that in his own wits lay the only chance of escape, and behind his casual manner he was racking his brains furiously.

The cold accents of the German took up the conversation:

'Have you anything to say before you are put to death as a spy?'

'Simply lots of things,' replied Tommy with the same urbanity as before.

'Do you deny that you were listening at that door?'

'I do not. I must really apologize—but your conversation was so interesting that it overcame my scruples.'

'How did you get in?'

Tuppence's meditations went off on another tack. She reviewed the events of last night carefully and persistently. Somehow, they seemed bound up with Sir James's enigmatical words...

Suddenly she gave a great start—the colour faded out of her face. Her eyes, fascinated, gazed in front of her, the pupils dilated.

'Impossible,' she murmured. 'Impossible! I must be going mad even to think of such a thing...'

Monstrous—yet it explained everything...

After a moment's reflection she sat down and wrote a note, weighing each word as she did so. Finally she nodded her head as though satisfied, and slipped it into an envelope which she addressed to Julius. She went down the passage to his sitting-room and knocked at the door. As she had expected, the room was empty. She left the note on the table.

A small page-boy was waiting outside her own door when she returned to it.

'Telegram for you, miss.'

Tuppence took it from the salver, and tore it open carelessly. Then she gave a cry. The telegram was from Tommy!

‘Oh, it isn’t that,’ gasped Tuppence with an almost hysterical laugh. ‘But thanking you very much, and all that, I think I’d better say no.’

‘I’d be obliged if you’d do me the favour to think it over until to-morrow.’

‘It’s no use.’

‘Still, I guess we’ll leave it like that.’

‘Very well,’ said Tuppence meekly.

Neither of them spoke again until they reached the ‘Ritz’.

Tuppence went upstairs to her room. She felt morally battered to the ground after her conflict with Julius’s vigorous personality. Sitting down in front of the glass, she stared at her own reflection for some minutes.

‘Fool,’ murmured Tuppence at length, making a grimace. ‘Little fool. Everything you want—everything you’ve ever hoped for, and you go and bleat out “no” like an idiotic little sheep. It’s your one chance. Why don’t you take it? Grab it? Snatch at it? What more do you want?’

As if in answer to her own question, her eyes fell on a small snapshot of Tommy that stood on her dressing-table in a shabby frame. For a moment she struggled for self-control, and then abandoning all presence, she held it to her lips and burst into a fit of sobbing.

‘Oh, Tommy, Tommy,’ she cried, ‘I do love you so—and I may never see you again....’

At the end of five minutes Tuppence sat up, blew her nose, and pushed back her hair.

‘That’s that,’ she observed sternly. ‘Let’s look facts in the face. I seem to have fallen in love—with an idiot of a boy who probably doesn’t care two straws about me.’ Here she paused. ‘Anyway,’ she resumed, as though arguing with an unseen opponent, ‘I don’t *know* that he does. He’d never have dared to say so. I’ve always jumped on sentiment—and here I am being more sentimental than anybody. What idiots girls are! I’ve always thought so. I suppose I shall sleep with his photograph under my pillow, and dream about him all night. It’s dreadful to feel you’ve been false to your principles.’

Tuppence shook her head sadly, as she reviewed her backsliding.

‘I don’t know what to say to Julius, I’m sure. Oh, what a fool I feel! I’ll have to say *something*—he’s so American and thorough, he’ll insist upon having a reason. I wonder if he did find anything in that safe—’

‘Dear old Conrad here,’ Tommy smiled deprecatingly at him. ‘I hesitate to suggest pensioning off a faithful servant, but you really ought to have a better watchdog.’

Conrad snarled impotently, and said sullenly, as the man with the beard swung round upon him:

‘He gave the word. How was I to know?’

‘Yes,’ Tommy chimed in. ‘How was he to know? Don’t blame the poor fellow. His hasty action has given me the pleasure of seeing you all face to face.’

He fancied that his words caused some discomposure among the group, but the watchful German stilled it with a wave of his hand.

‘Dead men tell no tales,’ he said evenly.

‘Ah,’ said Tommy, ‘but I’m not dead yet!’

‘You soon will be, my young friend,’ said the German.

An assenting murmur came from the others.

Tommy’s heart beat faster, but his casual pleasantness did not waver.

‘I think not,’ he said firmly. ‘I should have a great objection to dying.’

He had got them puzzled, he saw that by the look on his captor’s face.

‘Can you give us any reason why we should not put you to death?’ asked the German.

‘Several,’ replied Tommy. ‘Look here, you’ve been asking me a lot of questions. Let me ask you one for a change. Why didn’t you kill me off at once before I regained consciousness?’

The German hesitated, and Tommy seized his advantage.

‘Because you didn’t know how much I knew—and where I obtained that knowledge. If you kill me now, you never will know.’

But here the emotions of Boris became too much for him. He stepped forward waving his arms.

‘You hell-hound of a spy,’ he screamed. ‘We will give you short shrift. Kill him! Kill him!’

There was a roar of applause.

‘You hear?’ said the German, his eyes on Tommy. ‘What have you to say to that?’

‘Say?’ Tommy shrugged his shoulders. ‘Pack of fools. Let them ask themselves a few questions. How did I get into this place? Remember what dear old Conrad said—with *your own password*, wasn’t it? How did I get hold of

that? You don't suppose I came up those steps haphazard and said the first thing that came into my head?

Tommy was pleased with the concluding words of this speech. His only regret was that Tuppence was not present to appreciate its full flavour.

'That is true,' said the working man suddenly. 'Comrades, we have been betrayed!'

An ugly murmur arose. Tommy smiled at them encouragingly.

'That's better. How can you hope to make a success of any job if you don't use your brains?'

'You will tell us who has betrayed us,' said the German. 'But that shall not save you—oh, no! You shall tell us all that you know. Boris, here, knows pretty ways of making people speak!'

'Bah!' said Tommy scornfully, fighting down a singularly unpleasant feeling in the pit of his stomach. 'You will neither torture me nor kill me.'

'And why not?' asked Boris.

'Because you'd kill the goose that lays the golden eggs,' replied Tommy quietly.

There was a momentary pause. It seemed as though Tommy's persistent assurance was at last conquering. They were no longer completely sure of themselves. The man in the shabby clothes stared at Tommy searchingly.

'He's bluffing you, Boris,' he said quietly.

Tommy hated him. Had the man seen through him?

The German, with an effort, turned roughly to Tommy.

'What do you mean?'

'What do you think I mean?' parried Tommy, searching desperately in his own mind.

Suddenly Boris stepped forward, and shook his fist in Tommy's face.

'Speak, you swine of an Englishman—speak!'

'Don't get so excited, my good fellow,' said Tommy calmly. 'That's the worst of you foreigners. You can't keep calm. Now, I ask you, do I look as though I thought there were the least chance of your killing me?'

He looked confidently round, and was glad they could not hear the persistent beating of his heart which gave the lie to his words.

'No,' admitted Boris at last sullenly, 'you do not.'

'All right—say it! I can face facts. Supposing he's—dead! Well?'

'And all this business fiddles out. What are you going to do?'

'I don't know,' said Tuppence forlornly.

'You'll be darned lonesome, you poor kid.'

'I shall be all right,' snapped Tuppence with her usual resentment of any kind of pity.

'What about marriage?' inquired Julius. 'Got any views on the subject?'

'I intend to marry, of course,' replied Tuppence. 'That is, if—she paused, knew a momentary longing to draw back, and then stuck to her guns bravely—I can find some one rich enough to make it worth my while. That's frank, isn't it? I dare say you despise me for it.'

'I never despise business instinct,' said Julius. 'What particular figure have you in mind?'

'Figure?' asked Tuppence, puzzled. 'Do you mean tall or short?'

'No. Sum—income.'

'Oh, I—I haven't quite worked that out.'

'What about me?'

'You?'

'Sure thing.'

'Oh, I couldn't!'

'Why not?'

'I tell you I couldn't.'

'Again, why not?'

'It would seem so unfair.'

'I don't see anything unfair about it. I call your bluff, that's all. I admire you immensely, Miss Tuppence, more than any girl I've ever met. You're so darned plucky. I'd just love to give you a real, rattling good time. Say the word, and we'll run round right away to some high-class jeweller, and fix up the ring business.'

'I can't,' gasped Tuppence.

'Because of Beresford?'

'No, no, *no!*'

'Well then?'

Tuppence merely continued to shake her head violently. 'You can't reasonably expect more dollars than I've got.'

For a while they ran on under the trees in silence. It was a beautiful day. The keen rush through the air brought a new exhilaration to Tuppence.

'Say, Miss Tuppence, do you think I'm ever going to find Jane?'

Julius spoke in a discouraged voice. The mood was so alien to him that Tuppence turned and stared at him in surprise. He nodded.

'That's so. I'm getting down and out over the business. Sir James to-day hadn't got any hope at all, I could see that. I don't like him—we don't gee together somehow—but he's pretty cute, and I guess he wouldn't quit if there was any chance of success—now, would he?'

Tuppence felt rather uncomfortable, but clinging to her belief that Julius also had withheld something from her, she remained firm.

'He suggested advertising for the nurse,' she reminded him.

'Yes, with a "forlorn hope" flavour to his voice! No—I'm about fed up. I've half a mind to go back to the States right away.'

'Oh no!' cried Tuppence. 'We've got to find Tommy.'

'I sure forgot Beresford,' said Julius contritely. 'That's so. We must find him. But after—well, I've been day-dreaming ever since I started on this trip—and these dreams are rotten poor business. I'm quit of them. Say, Miss Tuppence, there's something I'd like to ask you.'

'Yes?'

'You and Beresford. What about it?'

'I don't understand you,' replied Tuppence with dignity, adding rather inconsequently: 'And, anyway, you're wrong!'

'Not got a sort of kindly feeling for one another?'

'Certainly not,' said Tuppence with warmth. 'Tommy and I are friends—nothing more.'

'I guess every pair of lovers has said that sometime or another,' observed Julius.

'Nonsense!' snapped Tuppence. 'Do I look the sort of girl that's always falling in love with every man she meets?'

'You do not. You look the sort of girl that's mighty often getting fallen in love with!'

'Oh!' said Tuppence, rather taken aback. 'That's a compliment, I suppose?'

'Sure. Now let's get down to this. Supposing we never find Beresford and—and—'

'Thank God, he's not a mind reader,' thought Tommy. Aloud he pursued his advantage:

'And why am I so confident? Because I know something that puts me in a position to propose a bargain.'

'A bargain?' The bearded man took him up sharply.

'Yes—a bargain. My life and liberty against—' He paused.

'Against what?'

The group pressed forward. You could have heard a pin drop. Slowly Tommy spoke.

'The papers that Danvers brought over from America in the *Lasstania*.'

The effect of his words was electrical. Every one was on his feet. The German waved them back. He leaned over Tommy, his face purple with excitement.

'*Himmel!* You have got them, then?'

With magnificent calm Tommy shook his head.

'You know where they are?' persisted the German.

Again Tommy shook his head. 'Not in the least.'

'Then—then—' angry and baffled, the words failed him.

Tommy looked round. He saw anger and bewilderment on every face, but his calm assurance had done its work—no one doubted but that something lay behind his words.

'I don't know where the papers are—but I believe that I can find them. I have a theory—'

'Pah!'

Tommy raised his hand, and silenced the clamours of disgust.

'I call it a theory—but I'm pretty sure of my facts—facts that are known to no one but myself. In any case what do you lose? If I can produce the papers—you give me my life and liberty in exchange. Is it a bargain?'

'And if we refuse?' said the German quietly.

Tommy lay back on the couch.

'The 29th,' he said thoughtfully, 'is less than a fortnight ahead—'

For a moment the German hesitated. Then he made a sign to Conrad.

'Take him into the other room.'

For five minutes, Tommy sat on the bed in the dingy room next door. His heart was beating violently. He had risked all on this throw. How would they decide? And all the while that this agonized questioning went on within him,

he talked flippanantly to Conrad, enraging the cross-grained doorkeeper to the point of homicidal mania.

At last the door opened, and the German called imperiously to Conrad to return.

'Let's hope the judge hasn't put his black cap on,' remarked Tommy frivolously. 'That's right, Conrad, march me in. The prisoner is at the bar, gentlemen.'

The German was seated once more behind the table. He motioned to Tommy to sit down opposite to him.

'We accept,' he said harshly, 'on terms. The papers must be delivered to us before you go free.'

'Idiot!' said Tommy amiably. 'How do you think I can look for them if you keep me tied by the leg here?'

'What do you expect, then?'

'I must have liberty to go about the business in my own way.'

The German laughed.

'Do you think we are little children to let you walk out of here leaving us a pretty story full of promises?'

'No,' said Tommy thoughtfully. 'Though infinitely simpler for me, I did not really think you would agree to that plan. Very well, we must arrange a compromise. How would it be if you attached little Conrad here to my person. He's a faithful fellow, and very ready with the fist.'

'We prefer,' said the German coldly, 'that you should remain here. One of our number will carry out your instructions minutely. If the operations are complicated, he will return to you with a report and you can instruct him further.'

'You're tying my hands,' complained Tommy. 'It's a very delicate affair, and the other fellow will muff it up as likely as not, and then where shall I be? I don't believe one of you has got an ounce of tact.'

The German rapped the table.

'Those are our terms. Otherwise, death!'

Tommy leaned back wearily.

'I like your style. Curt, but attractive. So be it, then. But one thing is essential, I must see the girl.'

'What girl?'

'My dear young lady, I can do nothing more, I fear. Our clues have all ended in thin air. You can take my word for it that there is nothing more to be done. If anything should arise, I shall be glad to advise you in any way I can.'

His words gave Tuppence an extraordinarily desolate feeling.

'I suppose you're right,' she said. 'Anyway, thank you very much for trying to help us. Good-bye.'

Julius was bending over the car. A momentary pity came into Sir James's keen eyes, as he gazed into the girl's downcast face.

'Don't be too disconsolate, Miss Tuppence,' he said in a low voice. 'Remember, holiday-time isn't always all playtime. One sometimes manages to put in some work as well.'

Something in his tone made Tuppence glance up sharply. He shook his head with a smile.

'No, I shan't say any more. Great mistake to say too much. Remember that. Never tell all you know—not even to the person you know best. Understand? Good-bye.'

He strode away. Tuppence stared after him. She was beginning to understand Sir James's methods. Once before he had thrown her a hint in the same careless fashion. Was this a hint? What exactly lay behind those last brief words? Did he mean that, after all, he had not abandoned the case; that, secretly, he would be working on it still while—

Her meditations were interrupted by Julius, who adjured her to 'get right in.'

'You're looking kind of thoughtful,' he remarked as they started off. 'Did the old guy say anything more?'

Tuppence opened her mouth impulsively, and then shut it again. Sir James's words sounded in her ears: 'Never tell all you know—not even to the person you know best.' And like a flash there came into her mind another memory. Julius before the safe in the flat, her own question and the pause before his reply, 'Nothing.' Was there really nothing? Or had he found something he wished to keep to himself? If he could make a reservation, so could she.

'Nothing particular,' she replied.

She felt rather than saw Julius throw a sideways glance at her.

'Say, shall we go for a spin in the park?'

'If you like.'

‘That remains to be seen,’ said Sir James gravely. The other hesitated.

‘You do not think I ought to go to the police?’

‘No, no. In all probability the young lady is with other relations.’

The doctor was not completely satisfied, but he saw that Sir James was determined to say no more, and realized that to try and extract more information from the famous K.C. would be mere waste of labour. Accordingly, he wished them goodbye, and they left the hotel. For a few minutes they stood by the car talking.

‘How maddening,’ cried Tuppence. ‘To think that Julius must have been actually under the same roof with her for a few hours.’

‘I was a darned idiot,’ muttered Julius gloomily.

‘You couldn’t know,’ Tuppence consoled him. ‘Could he?’ She appealed to Sir James.

‘I should advise you not to worry,’ said the latter kindly. ‘No use crying over spilt milk, you know.’

‘The great thing is what to do next,’ added Tuppence the practical.

Sir James shrugged his shoulders.

‘You might advertise for the nurse who accompanied the girl. That is the only course I can suggest, and I must confess I do not hope for much result. Otherwise there is nothing to be done.’

‘Nothing?’ said Tuppence blankly. ‘And—Tommy?’

‘We must hope for the best,’ said Sir James. ‘Oh yes, we must go on hoping.’ But over her downcast head his eyes met Julius’s, and almost imperceptibly he shook his head. Julius understood. The lawyer considered the case hopeless. The young American’s face grew grave. Sir James took Tuppence’s hand.

‘You must let me know if anything further comes to light. Letters will always be forwarded.’

Tuppence stared at him blankly.

‘You are going away?’

‘I told you. Don’t you remember? To Scotland.’

‘Yes, but I thought—’ The girl hesitated.

Sir James shrugged his shoulders.

‘Jane Finn, of course.’

The other looked at him curiously for some minutes, then he said slowly, and as though choosing his words with care:

‘Do you not know that she can tell you nothing?’

Tommy’s heart beat a little faster. Would he succeed in coming face to face with the girl he was seeking?

‘I shall not ask her to tell me anything,’ he said quietly. ‘Not in so many words, that is.’

‘Then why see her?’

Tommy paused.

‘To watch her face when I ask her one question,’ he replied at last.

Again there was a look in the German’s eyes that Tommy did not quite understand.

‘She will not be able to answer your question.’

‘That does not matter. I shall have seen her face when I ask it.’

‘And you think that will tell you anything?’ He gave a short disagreeable laugh. More than ever, Tommy felt that there was a factor somewhere that he did not understand. The German looked at him searchingly. ‘I wonder whether, after all, you know as much as we think?’ he said softly.

Tommy felt his ascendancy less sure than a moment before. His hold had slipped a little. But he was puzzled. What had he said wrong? He spoke out on the impulse of the moment.

‘There may be things that you know which I do not. I have not pretended to be aware of all the details of your show. But equally I’ve got something up my sleeve that *you* don’t know about. And that’s where I mean to score. Danvers was a damned clever fellow—’ He broke off as if he had said too much.

But the German’s face had lightened a little.

‘Danvers,’ he murmured. ‘I see—’ He paused a minute, then waved to Conrad. ‘Take him away. Upstairs—you know.’

‘Wait a minute,’ said Tommy. ‘What about the girl?’

‘That may perhaps be arranged.’

‘It must be.’

‘We will see about it. Only one person can decide that.’

‘Who?’ asked Tommy. But he knew the answer.

‘Mr Brown—’

‘Shall I see him?’

‘Perhaps.’

‘Come,’ said Conrad harshly.

Tommy rose obediently. Outside the door his gaoler motioned to him to mount the stairs. He himself followed close behind. On the floor above Conrad opened a door and Tommy passed into a small room. Conrad lit a hissing gas burner and went out. Tommy heard the sound of the key being turned in the lock.

He set to work to examine his prison. It was a smaller room than the one downstairs, and there was something peculiarly airless about the atmosphere of it. Then he realized that there was no window. He walked round it. The walls were filthily dirty, as everywhere else. Four pictures hung crookedly on the wall representing scenes from Faust. Marguerite with her box of jewels, the church scene, Siebel and his flowers, and Faust and Mephistopheles. The latter brought Tommy’s mind back to Mr Brown again. In this sealed and closed chamber, with its close-fitting heavy door, he felt cut off from the world, and the sinister power of the arch-criminal seemed more real. Shout as he would, no one could ever hear him. The place was a living tomb....

With an effort Tommy pulled himself together. He sank on to the bed and gave himself up to reflection. His head ached badly; also, he was hungry. The silence of the place was dispiriting.

‘Anyway,’ said Tommy, trying to cheer himself, ‘I shall see the chief—the mysterious Mr Brown and with a bit of luck in bluffing I shall see the mysterious Jane Finn also. After that—’

After that Tommy was forced to admit the prospect looked dreary.

Chapter XV

Tuppence Receives a Proposal



JULIUS sprang up.

‘What?’

‘I thought you were aware of that.’

‘When did she leave?’

‘Let me see. To-day is Monday, is it not? It must have been last Wednesday—why, surely—yes, it was the same evening that you—er—fell out of my tree.’

‘That evening? Before, or after?’

‘Let me see—oh yes, afterwards. A very urgent message arrived from Mrs Vandemeyer. The young lady and the nurse who was in charge of her left by the night train.’

Julius sank back again into his chair.

‘Nurse Edith—left with a patient—I remember,’ he muttered. ‘My God, to have been so near!’

Dr Hall looked bewildered.

‘I don’t understand. Is the young lady not with her aunt, after all?’

Tuppence shook her head. She was about to speak when a warning glance from Sir James made her hold her tongue. The lawyer rose.

‘I’m much obliged to you, Hall. We’re very grateful for all you’ve told us. I’m afraid we’re now in the position of having to track Miss Vandemeyer anew. What about the nurse who accompanied her; I suppose you don’t know where she is?’

The doctor shook his head.

‘We’ve not heard from her, as it happens. I understood she was to remain with Miss Vandemeyer for a while. But what can have happened? Surely the girl has not been kidnapped.’